ESPI European Space Policy Institute

A year of growth:

Advancing the European Space Agenda

ESPI Annual Report 2024





In January 2024, ESPI inaugurated its new premises in Vienna's first district.

Saks Afridi
2018
Sighting from the project Space Mosque

ESPI MEMBERS

Co-Founders:

FFG Promoting Innovation. · esa

Supported by:

Federal Ministry Republic of Austria Climate Action, Environment, Energy, Mobility, Innovation and Technology

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PORTUGAL SPACE

Read more about our membership structure on page 47

Statement from the Director of ESPI
H. Ludwig Moeller

Dear Readers, European Stakeholders, and International Partners,

As this annual report is being issued, geopolitical developments put our world order and established partnerships to a test, also in space. Calls for more European autonomy, repeated without much effect since 2022 and the start of the war in Ukraine move to the core of the debate. Deficiencies raised by the 2024 Draghi Report on Europe's competitiveness gain new significance. A new quality of political engagement and readiness to invest in European autonomy, security, and economic resilience is materialising. This new level of political dynamics may act as a game-changer, also for the space sector.

The need for a European space policy and strategy, engaging all actors, national, intergovernmental, EU, and the urgency to develop a competitive European space industry is more evident than ever. A true scale-up of efforts in space diplomacy is critical, to strengthen existing and to forge new international partnerships.

The value of independent analysis and recommendations in space policy matters, as provided by ESPI becomes a precious good. To reinforce its role, ESPI amended its statutes in 2024, giving new emphasis to the Institute's role as an advocate of European space policy globally, as facilitator of dialogue between European stakeholders and with international partners, for strengthening international cooperation, for building understanding and trust, for the promotion of peace and knowledge, for a livable environment, for prosperity and to the general benefit of society and future generations.

The past year witnessed a new level of reach and political impact of the Institute, enabled by the continued growth of resources by a factor of two since 2022. This facilitated new interregional dialogues and international partnerships in Asia and Latin America, ESPI's contribution to the G20 in Brazil, and fruitful dialogue leveraging the Vienna Space Diplomat platform. ESPI had the honour to provide support to the EU Presidency of Belgium and Hungary, and for the first time analysed the role of space in the elections of the European Parliament and the UK. POLSA joined ESPI as a new member, while a new agreement with Austria provides for a new level of support by our host country for 2025-2028, as we have settled in at our new HQ in the heart of Vienna. ESPI also increased its role in support to the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC) under the Presidency of Luxembourg. Finally, ESPI established its initial presence in Brussels, to strengthen its ties with EU institutions and Belgium.

ESPI transformed and performed also in 2024, with the highlight of the ESPI Autumn Conference on Security & Defence, a Round Table of Space Commands and a strong contribution to the IAC in Milan. Other work included the first ESPI space strategy workshop with members, advisors, and experts, critical analysis of the Draghi Report, studies on the use of commercial solutions in security & defence and the industrial and systemic benefits of space exploration, to name a few of the more than 50 publications of the year and the more than 160 events ESPI led or contributed to.

ESPI will continue to justify the trust put into the Institute by its members, European stakeholders and international partners, for Europe to develop into a space power, as a strong partner to the world.

The next years will be decisive for Europe in space and for ESPI, and I would like to conclude by thanking the ESPI General Assembly for entrusting me with a second mandate 2025-2028, during this most critical period. Thank you to Minister Gewessler and the ESA Council with all member states for supporting this mandate. It is an honour to lead this unique Institute and a brilliant ESPI team, with the active engagement of an extraordinary Advisory Council, under the long-term guidance of the General Assembly.



Statements from ESPI Co-founders

Director General, Innovation & Technology, at Austria's BMK

Henriette Spyra

Federal Ministry
Republic of Austria
Climate Action, Environment,
Energy, Mobility,
Innovation and Technology

It is with great pleasure that I welcome you to the 2024 Annual Report of the European Space Policy Institute. 2024 was a very eventful and intensive year for ESPI, which was managed with excellence and high quality by the ESPI team. Austria's Federal Ministry for Climate Action, Environment, Energy, Mobility, Innovation and Technology has been a reliable partner of ESPI since its foundation, and I am therefore very pleased that we have been able to significantly increase our financial support of ESPI with the funding agreement 2025-2028.

The City of Vienna is also a supporter of ESPI and not only contributes to the rental costs but also opens the doors of the City Hall for the ESPI Autumn Conference 2025. In today's complex and volatile geopolitical environment, the topic of the conference "Europe as a Space Power-Directionality & Priorities of Strategic Action" has become even more relevant for Europe. I would like to thank ESPI for fulfilling its role as a think tank with such diligence by providing European decision makers with independent policy research and strategic analysis on space-related issues and supporting European institutions, national governments and industry stakeholders to address complex space policy issues.

In line with its role, ESPI does not shy away from showing where action is needed for Europe to assert itself as a competitive space power. ESPI also plays an important role in 'building bridges' by bringing together the space and non-space sectors. The space sector is no longer an isolated industry, but an important enabler of economic change in all industries. In particular, the integration of space innovations in other sectors helps to create new markets, improve lives and increase economic resilience in a rapidly changing world. I assume that you, dear readers of this report, are already familiar with ESPI's new office at Schwarzenbergplatz 16. ESPI has been here since the beginning of 2024, which is an ideal place to work and network with the Austrian, European and international space community as well as existing and potential users of space-based data and services.



Director-General of the European Space Agency

Josef Aschbacher

Dear members of ESPI, dear European space community, dear international partners,

The future of Europe and its role as a strong partner to the world are at stake. War in Europe and shifts in global leadership and trade foundations bring unprecedented geopolitical repercussions. Established partnerships are put to a test and require Europe to redefine its global role, also in space. Collectively, we need to ascertain Europe's competitiveness and safeguard its economic resilience and security. Space ultimately steps outside its comfort zone and is becoming a key element of political decisions. New answers are required. Business as usual is no longer a valid option.

Space urgently needs to live up to its systemic potential, to become an integral part of sectorial policies and strategies, as a transformative enabler of the wider economy, of digitalisation and of our common security, including in support to European diplomacy.

ESA, effectively pooling most of Europe's space resources under a shared vision, stands ready to play its part, responding to the needs of its member states and working hand in hand with the European Commission. The recently unveiled ESA Strategy 2040 lays out five clear goals with corresponding objectives and strategic actions to respond to Europe's key societal needs, including for Europe's resilience, autonomy, competitiveness and growth.

In this endeavour, ESA, and Europe at large, needs ESPI, leveraging its independent analysis on space policy and strategy and efforts to facilitate dialogue, build relationships and strengthen international cooperation. ESPI increasingly plays a pivotal role in supporting Europe and its partners, bringing space and policy closer together and promoting European space policy globally.

2024 has been the first year of a most successful implementation of the ESA-ESPI cooperation agreement, approved by all ESA Member States. This agreement demonstrates a shared European recognition of ESPI's complementary role and added value, and I am happy that other members, such as ASI, or Austria, have entered into similar agreements. I invite other members to follow, to provide ESPI with the widest possible support, at a time when independent thinking and support to open dialogue have become a most valuable asset.

Dear readers, while Europe can be proud of its continued excellence and innovation in numerous areas, it increasingly trails behind in domains which stand at the core of space powers such as launchers, human space exploration and security & defence. 2025 will be a most decisive year, as we have no time to lose. At the ESA Ministerial Conference (CM25) Europe must scale up its commitment to space to protect our values, secure peace, and remain relevant for our trusted partners. This also requires to significantly increase funding for space to a much higher share of European GDP, including from other policy agendas historically not associated with space.



CHAPTER ONE:

HIGHLIGHTS

- Strategy, Security & Economy
- European Roots
- Education & Talent
- Increasing Cooperation with Members of ESPI
- ESPI Team at the 18th ESPI Autumn Conference

Highlights

#1 Strategy, Security, Economy
ESPI's work tied into Europe's policy reflection

In yet another year of turmoil for Europe and its place on the global stage, our research and engagement addressed key European policy issues.

SECURITY AND ECONOMIC DIMENSIONS TO UNDERPIN THE 2040 EUROPEAN SPACE STRATEGY

On 25 September in Zurich, at ESPI's first strategy workshop, "Perspectives on a European Space Strategy", ESPI members, advisors, and external experts identified security and defence as the most significant element a European space strategy should consider to secure peace, next to the economic dimension of space for prosperity. The result of this unique collaboration was compiled into a first-of-its-kind ESPI report "An Initial Perspective on a European Space Strategy 2040: From Vision Towards Implementation", released at the 17th European Space Conference in January 2025, as an input to the strategy work of national and European stakeholders.







ESPI's opening statemnt at the 2024 European Space Forum

EUROPE'S COMPETITIVENESS: SCRUTINISING THE DRAGHI REPORT

As the issue of European competitiveness took centre stage in policy discourse in Brussels and beyond, with the release of Mario Draghi's report on the future of European competitiveness, ESPI provided a dedicated analysis of the space-related parts of the report. While underlining that competitiveness and the innovation gap across the European space sector needs to be acutely addressed, our analysis also discussed the Report's few contentious space policy guidelines, providing a complementary and critical perspective to policymakers and institutions, underscoring that it will take a village to bolster European competitiveness.



The inaugural "Roundtable of European Space Commands and MoDs"

CALL FOR ACTION: BUILDING UP EUROPE'S POLITICAL WILL

Despite growing recognition of the value of space, Europe today lacks the political will at the true scale of its economic power and talent to become a full space power. This message notably resonated in our Director's remarks at both the 16th European Space Conference and 2024 European Space Forum in Brussels. While this goal is still within reach, the gap is widening. Clear funding commitments (ESA CM25, EU MFF, CM28) and strategic direction are preconditions to avoid Europe being pushed further down the global competitiveness scale, not only in space but across all sectors of the economy enabled and transformed by it.

SCALING EUROPEAN SPACE CAPABILITIES FOR SECURITY & DEFENCE

With the security and defence angle moving to the top of Europe's space agenda, the 18th ESPI Autumn Conference on 1-2 October, which convened over 250 guests, focused on "Scaling European Space Capabilities for Security and Defence", and was preceded by ESPI's first "Roundtable of European Space Commands and Ministries of Defence". The need to better leverage the existing space eco-system was at the core of the debate at the Conference, to meet civil security challenges and respond to military needs, and to develop a more integrated framework for civil, commercial and defence cooperation.

> Today, European ambition in space trails. We must reverse this trend; we must rapidly increase our investments in space. Europe must recognise that space is as important a military theatre as the air, land and sea. That means investing in our capabilities and protecting our access to critical orbital resources.
>
> **Anders Fogh Rasmussen**
> FORMER PRIME MINISTER OF DENMARK; FORMER NATO SECRETARY GENERAL
> *REMARKS FROM HIS KEYNOTE AT THE 18TH ESPI AUTUMN CONFERENCE*



Highlights

#2 European Roots
Reinforcing and Expanding our European Presence

2024 was a year of increased membership and collaboration with members, new cooperation agreements, and broadening our European presence whilst strengthening our ties with our host nation Austria and home city of Vienna.

GROWING MEMBERSHIP BASE AND INTENSIFYING COOPERATION WITH OUR MEMBERS

In 2024 we welcomed the Polish Space Agency (POLSA) as our 21st member, extending our membership base further across Europe, following the Luxembourg Space Agency (LSA) and Portuguese Space Agency in 2023, increasing the number of national agencies to 12, next to three international organisations, and six European industry members. 2024 was also marked by increased cooperation with our members through bilateral agreements and active involvement of our members and advisors in ESPI's research, engagement, and education activities. See the photo gallery on the next page for examples of these collaborations. Next to implementing the first year of our framework agreement 2024-2025 with one of our founders, ESA, and with ASI, with sizeable increase in support, in 2024 we signed a new Support Agreement with our co-founder, Austria, represented by the Austrian Federal Ministry of Climate Action, Environment, Energy, Mobility, Innovation and Technology (BMK). This new agreement will extend from 2025 to 2028.



Handshake ceremony at the 75th IAC on the occasion of POLSA becoming a member of ESPI



Our first event in Brussels (June 2024) after establishing an initial presence in the EU's capital on the place of space in the 2024 European Elections

INAUGURATION OF OUR NEW HOME IN THE HEART OF VIENNA

ESPI kicked off 2024 by inaugurating its new premises at Schwarzenbergplatz 16, in Vienna's first district. The inauguration marked the beginning of a new era for ESPI, and this new and larger space is fitting for increased engagement with the global space community, as the Institute grows in vision, ambition and staff, and deepens its connection with its home city of Vienna – the global gateway for space and centre of space diplomacy.


ESPI's new home at Schwarzenbergplatz 16 in the heart of Vienna's first district.

The new premises in the heart of Vienna will strengthen the Vienna Space Diplomat (VSD) community, initiated and facilitated by ESPI since July 2023. In 2024, the ESPI premises hosted six events organised within the VSD framework.

ESTABLISHING AN INITIAL PRESENCE IN BRUSSELS

In 2024, ESPI also expanded its European reach by establishing an initial presence in Brussels to reinforce ESPI's mission to provide an active forum and increase our role in support of decision-making at the EU level. Developing a stronger footprint in Brussels allows us to strengthen our influence and actively engage with key stakeholders involved in shaping EU policies and strategies. Such engagement is particularly crucial in the current complex geopolitical environment.

Within the first several months of ESPI's initial presence in Brussels, facilitated by our members BELSPO and European Space Agency through ESA's Brussels Office, we have:

- Strengthened collaboration with over 30 stakeholders.
- Hosted a first Brussels-based ESPI event, "Will Space Sit at the European Parliament?"
- Actively contributed to both the Belgian and the Hungarian EU Council Presidencies, looking forward to supporting the forthcoming Presidencies in 2025 and beyond.
- Took prominent stage in major Brussels conferences, including delivering the opening keynote at the European Space Forum 2024.

> ESPI has consistently produced policy recommendations and strategic insights that have helped develop the EU space ambition. We count on ESPI to continue helping to shape the EU space policy.
>
> **Timo Pesonen**
> DIRECTOR-GENERAL OF DG DEFENCE INDUSTRY AND SPACE IN THE EUROPEAN COMMISSION



Highlights

#3 Education & Talent
Fostering Europe's Future


Participants of the ESPI's Inaugural Space Policy Summer School, organized in n collaboration with the European Forum Alpbach (EFA)

While Europe continues to be home to the highest concentration of talent, education, workforce development, and talent attraction are key challenges that will confront the European space sector, and Europe at large, in the medium term. By giving new emphasis to its education activities, ESPI aims to contribute to this challenge and to a stronger, better connected, and more efficient space and space policy education ecosystem in Europe.

ESTABLISHING ESPI'S EDUCATION PORTFOLIO

2024 saw a sizeable acceleration of education-related activities at ESPI. Of note, ESPI convened more than 30 total education activities at our premises in Vienna and across Europe:



In 2024, ESPI also welcomed its first batch of visiting students from Flinders University in Adelaide, Australia, as part of a larger comprehensive partnership.


Visit of SIOI student association at ESPI in June


Visit of students from ELSA (The European Law Students' Association) at ESPI in July

ESPI INAUGURAL SPACE POLICY SUMMER SCHOOL

ESPI's Inaugural Space Policy Summer School took place from 19-23 August 2024 in Alpbach, one of the most beautiful locations in the Austrian Alps. The summer school was organised in collaboration with the European Forum Alpbach (EFA) and welcomed 50+ participants from over 10 different nationalities, with many different backgrounds.

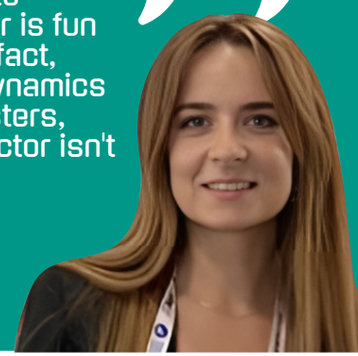
In fact, less than 30% of participants were currently working in the space sector, with others coming from fields such as international relations, politics, and engineering, amongst others. The week received some inspiring feedback from participants, notably that 60% of participants said they would now consider a career in the space sector, having not considered one before the summer school.

The programme consisted of five days of morning seminars which addressed four themes aligning with EFA's overall theme, "Moment of Truth": Security, Economy, Climate, and Policy. ESPI Director H. Ludwig Moeller was joined by four rotating co-chairs representing each theme, including: Gen. (Ret.) Michel Friedling, Former French Space Commander & Member of ESPI Advisory Council for the Security theme; Sinéad O'Sullivan, Economist at Harvard Business School & Member of ESPI Advisory Council for the Economy theme; Volker Liebig, Former Director of Earth Observation Programmes at ESA for the Climate theme; and Angelina Bekasova, Space & Innovation Policy Senior Expert at the Ministry of Economics of the Republic of Latvia for the Policy theme.

SPOTLIGHT ON EUROPE'S TALENT

ESPI conducted a European Space Sector Talent Study targeting students and young professionals to achieve a greater understanding of young professionals' and students' needs to enter the European space sector. This Talent Survey generated more than 500+ inputs and its results will be an integral part of a larger study in 2025, aimed at informing European policy makers about the supply and demand dynamics within the space sector.

> The rapid growth of the space economy will open doors for an entirely new wave of non-space industry professionals, recent graduates and political leaders for whom space will have to become the norm. Despite its complexity, the space sector is fun and can be taught in an engaging and accessible way. In fact, participants of all ages quickly and accurately grasp its dynamics through immersive games, stepping into the roles of ministers, experts, business leaders and scientists. Perhaps the sector isn't that complex after all!
>
> **Angelina Bekasova**
> SENIOR EXPERT AND HEAD OF SPACE POLICY, LATVIAN MINISTRY OF ECONOMICS
> *ONE OF THE SPEAKERS AT THE FIRST ESPI SPACE POLICY SUMMER SCHOOL*



INCREASING COOPERATION WITH MEMBERS OF ESPI



Workshop on ESPI's Institutional Evolution, held at the premises of Thales Alenia Space in Cannes in November.

Managing Director of the Austrian Research Promotion Agency (FFG), Karin Tausz, speaking at the inauguration of ESPI's new premises in January.





EUMETSAT hosting our General Assembly and Advisory Council meetings in May.



ESA's Director for Strategy, Legal and External Affairs, Eric Morel de Westgaver, appearing in the video outreach for the ESPI2040 vision "Space for Prosperity, Peace and Future Generations".

Joint event with UKSA on the 30th Anniversary of the IADC, organised under ESPI's Vienna Space Diplomat Initiative as a side event to the UN COPUOS Scientific and Technical Subcommittee in January.



ESA's Director of Science, Carolle Mundell, and President of the Italian Space Agency, Teodoro Valente, speaking in one of ESPI's sessions at the 16th European Space Conference in Brussels in January.



Frank Monteny, Director General for Research and Space at BELSPO with ESPI's Sara Dalledonne on the occasion of the establishment of ESPI's initial presence in Brussels in March.



ESPI's first Space Strategy Workshop in September at ETH Zurich, facilitated by the Swiss Space Office, welcoming ESPI members, advisors and external experts.



Director General of German Space Agency at DLR, Walther Pelzer, delivering a keynote at the 18th ESPI Autumn Conference in October.





Two-day seminar in Vienna for Norwegian researchers and thought leaders organised with NOSA in February.

Building on a long-standing collaboration, formalised with a Memorandum of Understanding in 2023, the Italian Space Agency and ESPI continue to enhance their contribution to the international space community. Through analysis and research on space policy, joint studies and initiatives, as well as awareness-raising events on policy and economic aspects, we support a shared vision for the future development of the sector.

Gabriella Arrigo
Director of International Affairs at the Italian Space Agency (ASI) and incoming President of the International Astronautical Federation (2026)



ESPI Team at the 18th ESPI Autumn Conference

OCTOBER 2024



The Institute's greatest strength is undoubtedly its remarkable team: a diverse, multicultural group of highly skilled professionals who are dedicated to advancing space policy both individually and collectively. As an independent yet well-connected think-tank, ESPI is both forward-thinking and deeply engaged with real-world challenges - exactly what Europe needs right now!

Sebastien Moranta
ACCELERATOR DEVELOPMENT COORDINATOR AT ESA AND FORMER RESEARCH MANAGER AT ESPI

ENGAGING WITH 200 ESPI ALUMNI

Since its founding in 2003 ESPI has welcomed close to 200 people of more than 30 nations, among its staff and global fellows. In 2024 we initiated new engagement activities with ESPI Alumni, starting with a gathering at the 75th IAC in Milan.

NATIONALITIES 22

AVERAGE AGE 31 YEARS

CHAPTER TWO:

ESPI IMPACT

ESPI By the Numbers

European Engagement

International Engagement

Global Impact

Strengthening European and International Engagement

ESPI's Key Publications in 2024

Highlights across our Research Streams:

Outlook 2025

ESPI BY THE NUMBERS

	2023 Data	2024 Data
Total Website Views	64,423	100,264
Total Website Users	9,839	11,055
Total LinkedIn Followers	12,768	17,120
Total LinkedIn Views	435,000	540,000

2024 Growth Rates

Website Views	Website Users	LinkedIn Followers	LinkedIn Engagement
+ 55.6%	+ 12.4%	+ 34%	+ 24%

6 **GLOBAL REGIONS WITH ESPI PRESENCE**
Amplifying our reach in 2024, we partnered, engaged, or cooperated with stakeholders in all global regions.

23 **EUROPEAN COUNTRIES ENGAGED**
We engaged in bilateral exchanges with national authorities and joined key space events in 23 out of 30 ESA and EU Member States.

50+ **ESPI PUBLICATIONS**
We published a host of Reports, Policy Briefs, our annual Yearbook, monthly Insights and Director's Perspectives, alongside a suite of other ESPI publications.

160+ **EVENTS AND FORUMS WITH ESPI INVOLVEMENT**
Our diverse team organised more than 30 and contributed to more than 130 events and forums around the world.

500,000+ **VIEWS OF ESPI CONTENT ON SOCIAL MEDIA**
Our online presence continues to reach European and international audiences, and 2024 showed a 50%+ increase in outreach on our social media channels, linking back to our newly designed and re-focused website.



In this rapidly changing world, ESPI has remained a trusted partner, successfully responding to the challenges of our time. Key milestones for our accomplishments are transparency, integrity and a dedicated, fact-driven team.

Evelyn Obernosterer-Egger
ESPI TREASURER

Top 5 Publications



POLICY VISION:
ESPI 2040 Space for Prosperity, Peace and Future Generations



ESPI REPORT 92:
Will Space sit in the European Parliament?



ESPI-BCG REPORT:
More than a Space Programme



ESPI POLICY BRIEF:
The Draghi Report: It Takes a Village



ESPI REPORT 90:
Bridging the Financing Gap in the European Space Sector

European Engagement

Next to the establishment of ESPI's initial presence in Brussels, expanded membership base, and historically our largest ESPI Autumn Conference, we strengthened engagement with our core audience of European stakeholders.

CONTINUED WORK WITH NATIONAL DECISION MAKERS

AUSTRIA – ESPI finalized the new Agreement with Austria's BMK Ministry, providing significantly increased support from our host nation from 2025-2028.

POLAND – The Polish Space Agency became the 21st member of ESPI, and our respective representatives held a ceremony during the 75th IAC in Milan.

ITALY – 2024 marked the first year of our strengthened cooperation with Italy after signing an MoU with ASI, including with dedicated activities in research, engagement. and education.

NORWAY – With NOSA, we organised a two-day seminar for Norwegian think tanks and researchers in Vienna, adding another layer of strengthening cooperation.

BELGIUM – BELSPO facilitated the establishment of ESPI's initial presence in Brussels and we supported the Belgian EU Council Presidency.

SWITZERLAND – We worked with SSO and ETH on the hosting of ESPI's first Space Strategy Workshop in Zurich. The Swiss Permanent Mission in Vienna hosted the organization of our annual VSD Summer Reception.

LUXEMBOURG – As part of our mandate in EISC, we worked closely with the 2024 Luxembourgish EISC Presidency, with the Luxembourgish Chamber of Deputies.

HUNGARY – ESPI supported Hungary's EU Council Presidency, including with a dedicated presentation to the EU Council's Space Working Party meeting.







ESPI Director Ludwig Moeller moderating the Heads of Agencies panel at the 16th European Space Conference

CONTRIBUTION TO CORE PLATFORMS FOR POLICY EXCHANGE

As part of our active role in more than 120 events in Europe in 2024, we dedicated particular effort in bringing the results of ESPI work to key stages. Notably, in Brussels, ESPI prominently contributed to the European Space Conference and European Space Forum, as well as to the EU Council's Space Working Parties under both Belgian and Hungarian Presidencies. Other key engagements, with ESPI keynotes, speeches and presentations included the Munich Security Conference, Novaspace, Space Defence & Security Summit, ILA Berlin, EISC Plenary, POLITICO - Competitive Europe Week, and ImpactCEE among others.

REINFORCEMENT OF ESPI'S ROLE IN EISC

Building on a long-term collaboration with the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC) framework, the year 2024 represented a milestone in this collaboration, with ESPI reinforcing its Secretariat role formally in the EISC Charter. ESPI also intends to further deepen its collaboration with parliaments.

LAUNCHING THE NETWORK OF EUROPEAN SPACE POLICY THINK TANKS (NEST)

In October 2024, ESPI officially launched its Network of European Space Policy Think Tanks (NEST) initiative at its premises following its 18th Autumn Conference, welcoming representatives from numerous think tanks with initial interest, including FRS, SWP, IAI, GLOBSEC, ISPL and others. NEST will function as forum to bring together think tanks and related organisations involved in space under a common framework coordinated by ESPI. Additionally, NEST will connect the existing bodies of research and engagement on European space policy and will offer a platform for dialogue and collaboration across and beyond the space domain, including areas such as economics and security. ESPI looks forward to continuing this initiative into 2025.

> ESPI is a globally renowned and highly active European think tank on space policy which addresses new challenges, diagnoses current trends, and indicates future solutions. Becoming a member of the ESPI is not just a membership, but a step into a world of possibilities, where collaboration fosters creativity, networking builds relationships, and common goals lead to collective European success. Our main goal is to become an actively contributing member of the European space ecosystem and to create a powerful network that transforms aspirations into achievements.
>
> **Col. Marcin Mazur**
> VICE PRESIDENT OF THE POLISH SPACE AGENCY



International Engagement

Part of ESPI's core mission to promote European space policy on a global level is made possible by our international engagement efforts.

OUR LARGEST PRESENCE EVER AT THE 75TH IAC

In 2024, we attended the 75th International Astronautical Congress (IAC) in Milan with our largest presence to date. In addition to our dedicated booth and related events we organised there, we also co-organised the Global Networking Forum, "Heads of Think Tanks" alongside the Aerospace Corporation's Center for Space Strategy and Policy, and the roundtable discussion, "Capital Across Continents" alongside ESA. In addition, we joined numerous other engagements throughout the IAC week, including with the heads of the Brazil's AEB and Argentina's CONAE.

MARKING THE FIRST ANNIVERSARY OF THE VIENNA SPACE DIPLOMAT

Our Vienna Space Diplomat (VSD) initiative celebrated its first anniversary with our annual VSD Summer Reception, hosted by the Permanent Mission of Switzerland and welcoming ESA Director of Human and Robotic Exploration (HRE), Daniel Neuenschwander. The VSD also convened several evening events alongside and in between UN COPUOS sessions to foster continued engagement with the diplomatic community in Vienna, on topics such as the strategic value of Earth observation, space weather and the challenges of space sustainability on the 30th anniversary of the IADC.



EXPANSION OF THE INTER-REGIONAL DIALOGUES

Building on the model of inter-regional space policy dialogues between Europe other global regions, in 2024 we hosted the first Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue between the Latin America and Caribbean Group (GRULAC) and European countries alongside the Permanent Mission of Argentina to the United Nations in Vienna. Additionally, ESPI was proud to continue in collaboration with Asia-Pacific Regional Space Agency Forum (APRSAF) and host the fourth ESPI-APRSAF Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue between Europe and the Asia-Pacific region.









NEW INTERNATIONAL PARTNERSHIPS

ESPI developed new Memoranda of Understanding with international partners, including with the US-based Aerospace Corporation's Center for Space Policy and Strategy and with the Korean Academy of Space Security (KASS). ESPI also established research partnerships with the Korea Aerospace Research Institute (KARI) and Space in Africa. We also initiated a visiting researcher programme with Flinders University in Adelaide, Australia and welcomed our first three researchers.

REINFORCEMENT OF GLOBAL FELLOWS PROGRAMME

A core part of ESPI's international engagement is its Global Fellows Programme, which welcomed six new Global Fellows in 2024 from a wide range of countries including Brazil, Chile, Japan, the US, and Zimbabwe. Our Global Policy Observatory, a new initiative to assess and analyse international space policies across key regions of interest for European space actors.

ESPI AT G20

Finally, building on successful initial engagement in 2023 during India's G20 presidency, ESPI again contributed to the annual space debate within the G20 framework by joining discussions held in Brazil during the G20 Space Economy Leaders Meeting (SELM) with an active contribution.

> With the launch of a new national space administration in 2024, South Korea is preparing several ambitious space programs, including L4 and lunar missions. Existing programs for space transportation and satellites are also being upgraded to new levels. I believe that space security and sustainability should be considered one of the most important space issues for South Korea and that it requires coordinated international cooperation. I hope to see more dialogues and joint efforts between South Korea and Europe in this regard.
>
> **Yong-Ik Byun**
> Vice Chairman of Korean Academy of Space Security (KASS)



GLOBAL IMPACT

NORTH AMERICA

ESPI participated in the 39th Space Foundation Space Symposium in Colorado Springs. ESPI also deepened cooperation with the Aerospace Corporation with a dedicated MoU and co-organisation of a Global Networking Forum at the 75th International Astronautical Congress under the topic “Heads of Think Tanks: Quo Vadis Space Sustainability”.

LATIN AMERICA

ESPI attended the G20 Space Economy Leaders Meetings in Brazil, and hosted the Inaugural Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue between the Latin America and Caribbean Group (GRULAC) and Europe alongside the UN COPUOS Legal Subcommittee and with support of the Argentinian Permanent Mission in Vienna.

AFRICA

ESPI attended the NewSpace Africa Conference in Luanda and participated in the first African Space Leadership Institute (ASLI) colloquium series on the African Outer Space Programme. ESPI also participated in TeanGeo 2024 and the New Space Horizons Conference in Tunis and Cairo, respectively. For the first time, the African perspective was also included in our annual “Space Venture” report series, thanks to a partnership with Space in Africa.

ASIA-PACIFIC

ESPI joined the 30th Annual Meeting of the Asia-Pacific Regional Space Agency Forum (APRSAF), as well as hosted the 4th Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue between Europe and Asia-Pacific. In Japan, ESPI attended SPACETIDE 2024 and the 6th Summit for Space Sustainability. Additionally, with Korea Aerospace Research Institute (KARI) we co-hosted a Workshop on Europe-ROK cooperation in STM and ESPI developed a new MoU with Korean Academy of Space Security (KASS). In Australia, ESPI delivered a keynote presentation at the 2nd Australian Space Cyber Forum and welcomed three master’s students as part of its joint Traineeship Programme with Flinders University.

MIDDLE EAST

ESPI continued its presence at main events in the Middle East region, joining both the Abu Dhabi Space Debate 2024 and the LEAP 2024 conference.

> “Space, by its nature, compels us to collaborate. It demands diverse expertise, and no single country or institution can afford space alone. We have collaborated with Europe for over 30 years, and it is the time to fully harness the benefit from this collaboration - let's co-create the future together.

H.E. Dr. Tidiane Ouattara
PRESIDENT OF THE AFRICAN SPACE COUNCIL OF THE AFRICAN SPACE AGENCY



STRENGTHENING EUROPEAN AND INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT



G20 Space Economy Leaders Meeting in Brazil

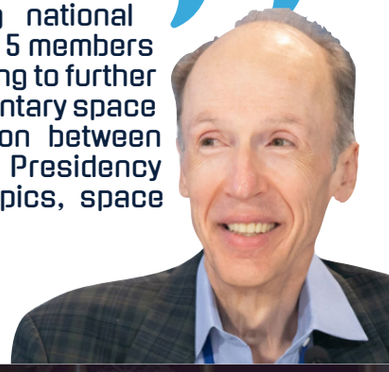


European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC) 2024 Workshop in Luxembourg


Munich Security Conference 2024

In 2024, the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC) continued in active engagement among national parliamentarians, growing its membership base to 15 members with the accession of Finland's parliament and looking to further increase the wider impact of EISC and inter-parliamentary space collaboration, leveraging the existing collaboration between EISC and ESPI. The 2024 Luxembourgish EISC Presidency addressed with particular emphasis two main topics, space legislation and the place of space at university.

Dr. Gérard Schockmel
Member of Luxembourg's Chamber of Deputies and Head of Luxembourg's Delegation to EISC



ESPI's Key Publications in 2024

REPORTS



Will Europe Sit in the European Parliament?



Space Venture Europe 2023



A Party for Everyone?



JOINT REPORT: European Patent Office, esa, ESPI

Propulsion Systems for Space



Bridging the Financing Gap in the European Space Sector



What's Next for Europe in Multilateral Engagement on Space Security?

ESPI YEARBOOK



Space Policies, Issues and Trends

+ Executive Summary



OTHER FORMATS



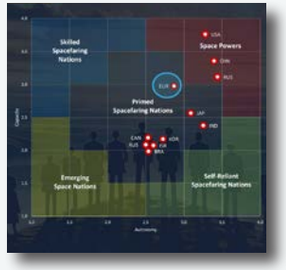
Factsheet on Space for Security & Defence



1st Roundtable of European Space Commands & Ministries of Defence



ESPI Speech: "Enhancing Space Cooperation in the EU"



ESPI's Opening Keynote at the 2024 European Space Forum

POLICY BRIEFS



The Draghi Report: It Takes a Village



From WRC-23 to the Next Cycle



Trade & Export Credit Agencies



Integrating Commercial Space for Military Applications in Europe

SPECIAL VIDEO OUTREACH

ESPI 2040

Bringing Our 2040 Vision for Europe to Life – Transformation of our ESPI2040 policy vision for Europe in space into a short video format





The Impact of Space on Industry, Economic Growth and Security in the UK's Shifting Political Landscape

DIRECTOR'S PERSPECTIVES & INSIGHTS



Director's Perspectives



ESPI Insights
RELEASED MONTHLY

"Our research is driven by a clear purpose: to shape, inform, and inspire policy and programmatic action across Europe for the widest possible impact of space to the benefit of society and our citizens."

Matija Renčelj
Research Manager at ESPI



2024 highlights across ESPI's thematic research areas

Green & Sustainable Societies

Key themes:

- Climate Resilience and Food Security
- Strategic Value of Earth Observation
- Space for Weather and Climate

BRIDGING CLIMATE POLICY AND SPACE COMMUNITIES IN THE MEDITERRANEAN TO ENHANCE CLIMATE RESILIENCE AND FOOD SECURITY THROUGH ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATIONS:

In collaboration with the Italian Space Agency (ASI), ESPI hosted the **Space for Climate Resilience and Food Security in the Mediterranean Basin** online workshop and will publish an accompanying report, "Space for Climate Resilience and Food Security" in 2025.

MAXIMIZING THE IMPACT OF EARTH OBSERVATION (EO REQUIRES DEMAND-DRIVEN SOLUTIONS ALIGNED WITH POLICY PRIORITIES, ENHANCED PUBLIC-PRIVATE COOPERATION, INTERNATIONAL COLLABORATION, AND IMPROVED DATA ACCESSIBILITY:

This is the best bet to address global challenges like climate change, food security, and security applications, as discussed during ESPI's VSD Evening Event, co-hosted with the International Society for Photogrammetry and Remote Sensing (ISPRS), "**The Strategic Value of Earth Observation**", in February 2024. This initiated a dedicated activity to promote the policy value of Earth observation.

SPACE FOR WEATHER AND CLIMATE:

Throughout 2024, ESPI engaged in several activities devoted to underpinning and strengthening the role space plays in meteorology and climate. Next to EUMETSAT's long-term membership in ESPI, we strengthened dialogue on space topics with the WMO, welcoming the Head of the WMO Space Programme to ESPI, and later in the year joining the ITU-WMO Regional seminar in Kazakhstan. In addition, we engaged work on safeguarding radiofrequency for Earth Observation applications, which resulted in a **joint event with EARSC** in early 2025.

As we mark the 75th Anniversary of WMO in 2025, space-enabled meteorology is more than just a tool for weather forecasting; it is a catalyst for innovation and resilience across various economic and policy sectors, vital not just for mitigating the impacts of extreme weather but also for responding to the challenges posed by climate change. As we progress with the Early Warnings for All initiative, WMO underscores the necessity of a free and unrestricted exchange of weather-related data, products, and services. Looking ahead, let us commit to harnessing the vast potential of space-based technologies and the collaborative ethos of the WMO. This commitment will be critical in protecting vital electromagnetic spectrum resources used for Earth observations.

Natalia Donoho

Chief, WMO Space Programme, at the World Meteorological Organization (WMO)



Security & Defence

Key themes:

- Engaging with Space Commands
- Commercial Solutions for Military Operations
- Multilateral Space Security

STRENGTHENING AND FACILITATING EUROPEAN REFLECTIONS ON SPACE SECURITY AND DEFENCE TOPICS ACROSS VARIOUS STAKEHOLDER COMMUNITIES:

The evolution of the international environment has pushed security and defence matters to the forefront of the space sector. Considering this, in September 2024, ESPI convened its first **Roundtable of European Space Commands and Ministries of Defence**, a closed-door event that welcomed representatives from eight European countries. The event supported two main objectives: exchanging views and best practices on the establishment of entities dedicated to the realm of military space; and reflecting on the approaches to establish and sustain cooperation between military and industrial space actors.

THERE IS RISING INTEREST IN USING COMMERCIAL SPACE SOLUTIONS FOR MILITARY OPERATIONS, WITH BOTH THE U.S. AND EUROPE SEEKING TO LEVERAGE SECURITY SOLUTIONS THROUGH THEIR SPACE INDUSTRIES:

The ESPI Policy Brief, **"Integrating Commercial Space for Military Applications in Europe: A Challenge and Opportunity"**, assesses that while the United States has started to operationalise its interest in leveraging commercial space for the military with the release of two strategies by the DoD and Space Force, the situation in Europe is less advanced. European actors need to identify the areas where the integration of commercial actors would be the most valuable and must agree on the depth of Europeanisation for the implementation of this process to respond to sovereignty requirements.

WHILE ALL COUNTRIES SEEK ORBITAL SECURITY, GEOPOLITICAL TENSIONS AND OVERLAPPING INITIATIVES RISK UNDERMINING SPACE SECURITY EFFORTS:

Consequently, space security issues have been at the forefront of the space agenda in the past years, and several mechanisms and fora have been set up to address them also in the UN framework. The ESPI report, **"What's Next for Europe in Multilateral Engagement on Space Security? The UN OEWG and its Success(ors)"** identifies lessons from past space security efforts conducted at the international level; analyses the recommendations sketched by the Open-Ended Working Group on Reducing Space Threats through Norms, Rules and Principles of Responsible Behaviours (OEWG); and outlines considerations for the future European approach.

We need to bring space as a question of safety and security to the political debate and to our societies while messaging that space is the future of our welfare and that space is something we need to protect and defend, like we protect other critical infrastructures.

Maj. Gen. Michael Traut

Commander of German Space Command



Exploration & Science

Key themes:

Scaling up European Ambition | **Wider Benefits of Space Exploration** | **Focus on the Moon**

CONTINUED ESPI'S CALL FOR INCREASED EUROPEAN AMBITION IN SPACE EXPLORATION:

Following up on support provided to the formulation of the "Revolution Space" Report by the High-Level Advisory Group in 2023, ESPI continued and reinforced advocating for an increased European ambition in space exploration, in particular human space exploration. All big space powers but Europe consider space exploration, especially human spaceflight, as a key component of their space strategy and use it as a tool leveraged far beyond the space sector, for the LEO economy, for industrial competitiveness, from education to diplomacy and day-to-day politics. Exploration is a crucial component that drives the growth within, pushes the boundaries of innovation and attracts the best and brightest to join the space industry

UNLOCKING CROSS-FERTILISATION EFFECTS FOR THE SPACE INDUSTRY:

Our research throughout in 2024 analysed the cross-fertilisation effects of space exploration on other activities in the space sector (e.g. propulsion, refuelling, robotics), as well as on markets beyond its perimeter (e.g. food & agriculture, pharmaceutical, automotive). The 16th European Space Conference in January 2024 underlined the need to embrace all dimensions of space exploration – business opportunities, scientific excellence, security and defence aspects, and inspiration.

WHAT FUTURE FOR LUNAR EXPLORATION:

During the year, ESPI experts actively contributed to numerous events, platforms, and media requests focused on policy, commercial, regulatory and security aspects of human activities in lunar and cis-lunar space (including the Outer Space Institute's Workshop on cis-lunar security in Vancouver), responding to accelerating global efforts in lunar exploration and utilisation. Building on this momentum, in late 2024 we launched new research with JAXA on future lunar markets.

In an era of rapid disruptions to cooperation and an increasingly transactional world, Europe needs to broaden its exploration capabilities. We must go beyond reducing dependencies - securing lasting autonomy and creating opportunities for international leadership.

Daniel Neuenschwander
Director of Human and Robotic Exporation at the European Space Agency (ESA)



Industry, Innovation, Finance & Workforce

Key themes:

Alternative Finance | **Space Investment Trends** | **ECAs and Trade Agencies**

DESPITE GROWING SECTOR INVESTMENT, MANY STARTUPS STRUGGLE TO SECURE FOLLOW-UP FUNDING, RAISING CONCERNS ABOUT SCALABILITY AND WHO WILL BRIDGE THESE FUNDING GAPS:

The ESPI report, "Bridging the Financing Gap in the European Space Sector: Alternative Funding Pathways in Tightening Markets", delves into the intricacies of investment trends, funding mechanisms, and offers strategic recommendations informed by the current and future state of financing in the sector. The report examines alternative financial mechanisms and vehicles, beyond venture capital and established public programmes, to make best use of public investments to attract private funds, laying out a roadmap of strategic recommendations to navigate the complexities of this evolving sector.

TRACKING PRIVATE INVESTMENT IN THE SPACE SECTOR, FOCUSING ON INVESTMENT DATA FOR GLOBAL, EUROPEAN, CHINESE, AND AFRICAN MARKETS:

The 2023 edition of ESPI's annual "Space Venture" report found that Europe's space sector saw a 7% drop in private investment to €942 million, despite 2022 and 2023 accounting for over half of all investments since 2014, while global space investments declined 32% to €6 billion, mainly due to the SPAC downturn, fewer large acquisitions, and reduced venture capital. China's space sector has raised €7.5 billion since 2014, dominated by a few key players, while Africa's space startups secured €184 million since 2015, with 84% raised after 2021.

EUROPE'S ENABLING POLICIES, TRUSTED REPUTATION, AND REGULATORY ADVANTAGES POSITION IT TO EXPAND ITS SPACE INDUSTRY, STRENGTHEN ITS GLOBAL ROLE, AND BOOST TECHNOLOGY EXPORTS BY LEVERAGING ECAS AND TRADE AGENCIES:

ESPI's Policy Brief, "Trade & Export Credit Agencies, a Strategic Enabler in the Space Data Economy", argues that Export Credit Agencies (ECAs) and trade agencies play a pivotal role in addressing funding gaps, facilitating partnerships, and expanding European industry reach, especially in emerging markets seeking capacity building and advanced technologies. They position Europe as a trusted global trade partner, support European competitiveness, and contribute to the prosperity of European society.

To secure Europe's future in space technology, it's essential for European policymakers to adopt strategies that drive innovation and industrial growth. The Austrian space sector is poised to play a pivotal role in enhancing our continent's competitive edge.

Dieter Grebner
Executive Committee President, Austrospace



Space as an Asset

Key themes:

Evolution of Space Debris Mitigation

Zero Debris

Access to Spectrum Rights

WRC-23 URGES OPERATORS AND EUROPEAN POLICYMAKERS TO PRIORITIZE WRC DECISIONS AND INTERIM POLICY MILESTONES AMID GROWING SPACE-BASED CONNECTIVITY:

The ESPI policy brief "**From WRC-23 to the Next Cycle: How to Make Everyone Happy? (Hint: You Can't)**", provides an overview of the World Radiocommunication Conference 2023 (WRC-23). Key outcomes included new frequency allocations for aviation, Earth observation, and space weather monitoring, alongside expanded mobile service bands, often at the expense of satellite services. With increasing competition between space and terrestrial networks, Europe must strengthen its regulatory frameworks, enhance industry collaboration, and prioritize space sustainability to remain competitive in the global connectivity landscape.

GLOBAL SPACE DEBRIS MITIGATION EFFORTS ARE ADVANCING WITH STRICTER INTERNATIONAL MEASURES, BUT FRAGMENTATION AND POOR COORDINATION HINDER EFFECTIVE IMPLEMENTATION:

In recent years, the issue of space debris and related safety and sustainability challenges have gained significant global attention, including in non-space communities. The ESPI report, "**A Party for Everyone? Analysing International Efforts in Space Debris Mitigation**", offers a comparative analysis of key international instruments and challenges in mitigating space debris.

ESPI STRENGTHENS ITS COMMITMENT TO SPACE SUSTAINABILITY BY SIGNING THE "ZERO DEBRIS CHARTER":

ESPI is proud to be a **signatory of the Zero Debris Charter**, a first-of-its-kind initiative in terms of covering technical requirements, policy considerations, and capability development commitments. The Zero Debris Charter was written by and for the global space community with the aim of shaping the global consensus on space sustainability and gathers a wide and varied array of space entities to define ambitious and measurable space debris mitigation and remediation targets for 2030.

In today's rapidly evolving space industry, it is important to remember that our real competition extends beyond Europe's borders. By focusing on external competition, we unite to strengthen our collective capabilities.

David Cavailollès
Chief Executive Officer at Arianespace



OUTLOOK 2025

BUILDING STRENGTH AND RESILIENCE

EUROPE IN SPACE:
At this point in time, full of uncertainties, any outlook on what 2025 may bring is a challenge.

Yet, it is most likely that the unique geopolitical disruptions of our time will have an irreversible effect on Europe, triggering a new level of ambition for increased sovereignty, for a stronger economy and competitive industry, for taking things into its own hands, for reinforcing existing and building new partnerships, also in space.

It will "take a village", the determination of all political decision makers and space actors, institutional and in industry to realize such ambition, to link policy to space, to leverage today's political dynamics as a game-changer, to federate (rather than unify) space policies and strategies to best effect, to raise space investments significantly to implement new flagship programmes from space applications and exploration to security and defence. The ESA Ministerial Conference 2025 will be a moment of truth to confirm that new ambitions indeed translate into increased programme action and funding support.

ESPI AGENDA
ESPI will support this evolution with a stronger focus on political impact, by promoting the policy value of space and its benefits to society and the economy, in the domain of Earth observation, for security and in other domains, for diplomacy. The ESPI Autumn Conference will be devoted to the theme of "Europe as a Space Power" and for the first time will be hosted at the prestigious Vienna town hall, at a new scale and including a high-level space policy debate. ESPI will be co-organising the 3rd ESA Security Conference in Poland and will provide additional perspectives on European space strategies, with an emphasis on the role and future of the industrial foundations, which Europe requires and urgently needs to secure.

The new Centre for Sustainability and Resilience will become operational at ESPI. ESPI will further scale-up its efforts in support for space diplomacy, with the ambition to reinforce links with Japan, India, South Korea, and other regions and emerging space powers. A new cooperation with the Bertelsmann Foundation will allow the Institute to support transatlantic dialogue and expand the outreach of ESPI's work to build bridges towards other regions and communities. The outreach via media, beyond the space sector to the wider public will be reinforced.

ESPI is expecting the growth of its membership base to continue, including the addition of the recently established Spanish Space Agency. The institutional evolution of ESPI in Austria will be the pursuit towards the status of a Quasi-International Organisation. The viability of an increased presence of ESPI in Europe will be explored, including possible cooperation with the European University Institute in Florence. These efforts aim at increasing the resilience of the organisation, at a time when independent analysis and open debate are endangered in parts of the world.

The Institute will continue its path of growing influence, at the pace and with the persistence and grit of a NewSpace actor.

CHAPTER THREE:

ABOUT US

ESPI Culture

Meet the Team

ESPI General Assembly

ESPI Advisory Council

Budget

Beyond 2025

ESPI Culture

ESPI's culture is driven by its team of experts who work together to foster a welcoming, proactive, and empowering work environment.

This allows our team to strive for excellence in proposing recommendations to policymakers and advancing the European space agenda.

LEVERAGING DIVERSITY, ENERGY AND GRIT

Our team prides itself on its gender balance and professional diversity. Out of 44 staff members who worked at ESPI throughout 2024, 21 team members were male and 23 were female.

In terms of our professional diversity, we are proud to say that our team members fall across a diverse spectrum

41% from an international affairs and political science background

23% from a business and economics background

18% from a legal background

11% from an engineering and science background

Fostering such a diverse team exposes our team members to expertise stemming from different fields and allows for inter-career learning and mentorship. This is our secret weapon in tackling Europe's greatest space policy challenges, as our research, recommendations, and presence at various engagements benefit from the diverse perspectives, points of view, and experiences our team brings.



EMPOWERING OUR TEAM

At ESPI, we recognize that the whole is more than the sum of its parts, which is why we strive to empower each of our team members in their professional endeavours. While our work speaks for itself, we are committed to spotlighting our experts to give them a chance to share their work with audiences both in Europe and beyond.







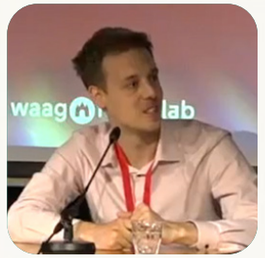



Members of the ESPI Team offered their expertise at

160+

events in 2024








ESPI Culture



FOSTERING TALENT

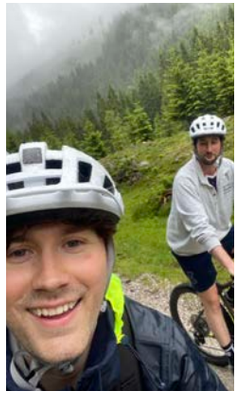
At ESPI, we are dedicated to inspiring and supporting young and brilliant minds and empowering the next generation of talent. As a long-term practice, ESPI has been running a paid internship programme for Europe's young professionals, fully integrating them into ESPI's team and activities. By providing paid internships to candidates from diverse backgrounds, we aim to cultivate the development of emerging professionals in the ever-evolving realm of space policy.

This initiative, coupled with continued cooperation with our members on welcoming their secondments at ESPI, usually young professionals, reflects our unwavering commitment to encouraging the next generation's active participation in shaping the future of Europe, in space and beyond.

Continuing in the recent dynamics, the attractiveness of ESPI as a workplace further grew in 2024. In the several recruitment campaigns launched during the year, we have cumulatively received more than 1,200 applications.

Additionally, through ESPI's Global Fellows Programme aiming primarily to deepen knowledge, facilitate dialogue and promote active engagement between European and non-European stakeholders, we also include our several Global Fellows as part of ESPI's fabric.









> At ESPI we embrace diversity of all kinds. In particular, our team is diverse in terms of origin (more than 20 different nationalities!) and professional background. This way we ensure to get different perspectives and the broader picture in our work. Also, the gender ratio in 2024 was almost balanced, and this trend is set to continue in 2025. Male and female qualities are appreciated equally at ESPI, and our different teams (research, administration and communication) strive to complement each other in the best possible way.
>
> **Iris Puchner**
> HR and Administration Officer at ESPI



ESPI staff during the 1st ESPI Space Policy Summer School, organised in collaboation with European Forum Alpbach, in the Austrian Alps, in August 2024.



Meet the ESPI Team

WHAT WE DO

- Secretariat & Management
- Research
- Communications & Engagement
- Administration & Finance

ESPI in 2024

- 22 NATIONALITIES
- 48% ♂ / 52% ♀ GENDER BALANCE
- AVERAGE AGE 31 Years
- 16 NEW FACES in 2024 +

Entered ESPI orbit in 2024

Departed ESPI Orbit in 2024 or Q1 2025


H. Ludwig Moeller
DIRECTOR


Evelyn Obernosterer-Egger
TREASURER


Matija Renčelj
RESEARCH MANAGER


Marco Aliberti
ASSOCIATE MANAGER AND LEAD ON INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT


Tomas Hrozensky
SENIOR RESEARCHER AND LEAD ON EUROPEAN ENGAGEMENT


Alida Mirkovic
HEAD OF DIRECTOR'S OFFICE


Mathieu Bataille
RESEARCH FELLOW AND LEAD ON SECURITY & DEFENCE


Sara Dalledonne
RESEARCH FELLOW AND LEAD ON EU RELATIONS AND REGULATORY AFFAIRS


Gabriele Redigonda
RESEARCH FELLOW AND LEAD ON GREEN AND SUSTAINABLE SOCIETIES


Clemence Poirier
RESEARCH FELLOW


Clelia Iacomino
SENIOR ASSOCIATE FELLOW


Lucas Bersegol
RESEARCH FELLOW SECONDED BY CNES


Alberto Rueda Carazo
RESEARCH FELLOW


Jermaine Gutierrez
RESEARCH FELLOW


Laura Corbett
RESEARCH FELLOW


Giulia Pavesi
RESEARCH FELLOW


Lars Petzold
RESEARCH FELLOW


Lina Pohl
RESEARCH FELLOW SECONDED BY DLR AND GERMANY & AUSTRIA RELATIONS OFFICER


Bianca Santi
RESEARCH FELLOW


João Falcão Serra
RESEARCH FELLOW


Andreas Kapounek
ESA YGT IN SPACE ECONOMY AND COMMERCE


Paul Silye
ECSECO YGT


Costanza Crivelli Visconti
RESEARCH FELLOW SECONDED BY ASI


Andrea Alberti
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW SECONDED BY ASI-SIOI


Irene Saiz Briones
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW


James Francis
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW


Anastasiia Posnova
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW


Julien Potin
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW


Shadi Rochard
JUNIOR RESEARCH FELLOW


Lorenzo Bertolli
RESEARCH INTERN


Justine Dousset
RESEARCH INTERN


Juan Galera
RESEARCH INTERN


Giusi Discenza
RESEARCH INTERN


Valentin Hoffmann
RESEARCH INTERN


Alexandra Chronopoulos
COMMUNICATIONS OFFICER


Sonja Agata Biscan
ENGAGEMENT OFFICER


Julia Drössler
GRAPHIC DESIGNER


Marianne Graff
COMMUNICATIONS & ENGAGEMENT INTERN


Lena Koeck
MANAGEMENT ASSISTANT AND DATA PROTECTION OFFICER


Reza Rezaie
IT ADMINISTRATOR


Petra Walter
ACCOUNTANT AND CONTROLLER


Iris Puchner
HR AND ADMINISTRATION OFFICER


Gerrel Ricardo Michel
ACCOUNTANT


Verena Eiboeck
FINANCIAL ASSISTANT

Global Fellows

Individual collaborations facilitated through our Global Fellows Programme, to deepen knowledge, facilitate dialogue and promote active engagement between European and non-European stakeholders.


Aoife Van Linden Tol
GLOBAL FELLOW


Daniel Porras
GLOBAL FELLOW


Rorisang Moyo
GLOBAL FELLOW


Leyton Wells
GLOBAL FELLOW


Victoria Valdivia
GLOBAL FELLOW


Tales Gaspar
GLOBAL FELLOW


Yui Nakama
GLOBAL FELLOW


Vinicius Guedes de Oliveira
GLOBAL FELLOW

> Space is truly global and continued engagement with different stakeholders beyond the European space community is fundamental to promote European space policy on a global level. Our Global Fellows Programme aims exactly to achieve this important objective by expanding ESPI's international connections, tapping into global expertise and networks, and in turn reinforcing Europe's role as partner to the world.
>
> **Marco Aliberti**
> ASSOCIATE MANAGER AND LEAD ON INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT

Visiting Researchers

Short-term research visits at ESPI by external European and international partners.


Marianna Valente
VISITING RESEARCHER
POLITECNICO DI TORINO


Ellen Feeney
VISITING RESEARCHER
FLINDERS UNIVERSITY


Eloise Clarke
VISITING RESEARCHER
FLINDERS UNIVERSITY


Sailor Tyler
VISITING RESEARCHER
FLINDERS UNIVERSITY

Statement from the Chair of the ESPI General Assembly

Andreas Geisler

HEAD OF AERONAUTICS AND SPACE AGENCY AT THE AUSTRIAN RESEARCH PROMOTION AGENCY (FFG)

Dear Reader,

In 2024, the European Space Policy Institute (ESPI) moved into its wonderful new premises at Schwarzenbergplatz 16, followed by a festive inauguration event. Over the course of the year, the concept of blending office space with art and events proved to be highly successful.

The year also began with a new, significantly expanded four-year funding agreement with the Austrian Federal Ministry for Climate Action. Starting in 2024, the composition of ESPI's Advisory Council has evolved, reflecting the growing reach of ESPI within the European space ecosystem. We are delighted to welcome Etienne Schneider, the former Deputy Prime Minister of Luxembourg, as the new Chair of the ESPI Advisory Council, as well as five new members, each bringing a unique perspective to the group.

There was also a further increase in membership by the Polish Space Agency and growing interest from both public and private stakeholders. Additionally, the statutes were amended, with particular emphasis placed on the enhanced wording of ESPI's mission and purpose. A deep reflection on ESPI's institutional evolution took place during the General Assembly, including a dedicated workshop held in November 2024 at Thales Alenia Space Headquarters in Cannes.

The cooperation between ESPI and its members was specifically reinforced, including a bilateral agreement with the Italian Space Agency (ASI), continued secondments, hosting of events, and initiatives. For the first time, the 2024 General Assembly was held at a member's premises – in May at EUMETSAT.

Education remains a cornerstone of ESPI's mandate and its steadfast commitment to empowering young talent, demonstrated by the internship program. This commitment underscores ESPI's dedication to integrating the next generation into the space sector and fostering their impact.

The General Assembly approved the re-election of the ESPI Director H. Ludwig Moeller for the term from 2025 to 2028, and also renewed the mandate of Evelyn Obernosterer-Egger as ESPI's Treasurer for another three-year term until 2027. Additionally, the General Assembly adopted a budget of €3.5 million for 2025, marking another record high.

Particular recognition in 2024 goes to the ESPI Admin Team which excellently manages the strong growth of the ESPI team. A dedicated and consistent strategy to scale up IT investments, the work environment, controlling, and skills has been key to maintaining stability amidst the growing complexity towards the emerging quasi-international organization.

I would like to congratulate the entire high-performing ESPI team on their achievements in 2024.



ESPI Mission & Agenda

FOR A STRONG EUROPE, AS A PARTNER TO THE WORLD

Since 2003, ESPI has served as Europe's leading and independent think tank for space and advocate for European space policy. Working in a non-profit capacity for the benefit space can bring to society and economy, ESPI's mission is to:

- Promote European space policy on an international level on strategic space issues such as:
  - Space applications to promote general benefit and prosperity;
  - Security and defence to promote peace;
  - Exploration and science to promote knowledge, inspiration, and European identity;
  - Climate protection and sustainability to promote a liveable environment; and
  - Training the next generation of talent.
- Raise public awareness of these strategic space issues.
- Provide independent analyses, proposals, and recommendations on these strategic space issues to European decision-makers and institutions.

To fulfill this mission, ESPI:

- Facilitates informed dialogue and relationships between key stakeholders, shaping intergovernmental, multilateral and European discourse and public debate, and strengthening international cooperation;
- Aims to build understanding and trust, increase efficiency in space policy and accelerate decision-making processes;
- Provides perspectives and presents paths for negotiations and agreements, in decision-making bodies of ESPI members, within structures of national governments, European institutions and international organisations.

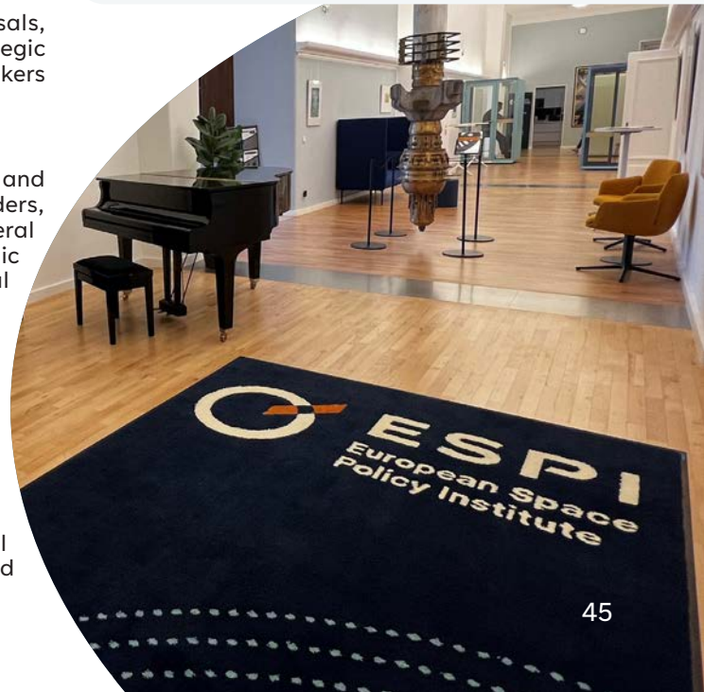
This is accompanied by independent proposals, recommendations and by measures to raise public awareness, supported by ESPI's independent and autonomous research and analysis work.

ESPI works to fulfil its mission through the ESPI Agenda, which is comprised of three overarching streams:

RESEARCH ESPI's comprehensive and high-quality research serves as the cornerstone for well-founded proposals and recommendations to European decision-makers and institutions.

ENGAGEMENT ESPI provides a platform for dialogue in Europe and internationally with diverse stakeholders in and beyond the space sector.

EDUCATION ESPI supports a European education ecosystem that can nurture and retain a talented and skilled workforce.



ESPI Governance Structure

ESPI'S GENERAL ASSEMBLY

ESPI is governed by a General Assembly, which defines its general long-term guidelines and approves the annual report on activities, financial report and annual budget.

The General Assembly is chaired by the departmental head of Aeronautics and Space Agency (ALR) of Austrian Research Promotion Agency (FFG), co-founder of ESPI.

ESPI was founded in 2003 and is currently supported by two founding members and its 19 regular members.

ESPI's Statutes were amended in November 2024 to reflect the evolution of the Institute. The General Assembly re-elected ESPI's Director and ESPI's Treasurer at its November 2024 meeting.

ESPI'S SECRETARIAT

ESPI is managed by the Secretariat composed of the Director and the Treasurer and supported by ESPI's own staff as well as staff seconded by members.

ESPI'S ADVISORY COUNCIL

The Advisory Council provides the ESPI Secretariat with medium-term recommendations with respect to the activities of the Institute.

It is of great value for governments, politicians, businesses, and research communities to have access to objective and independent analyses of various space-related issues. We all need to be professionally challenged to improve ourselves, sometimes change our mindset, set the right priorities, and create well-thought-out strategies. NOSA' s close collaborations with ESPI plays an important role in helping us understand the potential contribution of space to achieving strategic goals in a variety of policy areas.

Christian Hauglie-Hanssen
Director General of the Norwegian Space Agency



Members of ESPI

ESPI Co-Founders:

esa

FFG Promoting Innovation.

Supported by:

Federal Ministry
Republic of Austria
Climate Action, Environment,
Energy, Mobility,
Innovation and Technology

Agenzia Spaziale Italiana

cnes CENTRE NATIONAL D'ÉTUDES SPATIALES

EUMETSAT

European Commission

LSN LUXEMBOURG SPACE AGENCY

Belgian Science Policy Office belspo

DLR

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Norsk Romsenter Norwegian Space Agency

PLSA

PORTUGAL SPACE

beyond gravity

rosa

ThalesAlenia Space

EUTELSAT GROUP

arianespace arianeGROUP

OHB

EXOLAUNCH

Schweizerische Eidgenossenschaft
Confédération suisse
Confederazione Svizzera
Confederaziun svizra

Swiss Confederation

Federal Department of Economic Affairs, Education and Research EAER
State Secretariat for Education, Research and Innovation SERI
Swiss Space Office

Europe is a trusted and reliable partner on the global space stage, and ESA plays a key role in this respect. We need to leverage that for building our future. ESPI's international engagement can be a critical element in building bridges between Europe and its partners in the world.

Eric Morel de Westgaver
ESA Director of Strategy, Legal and External Affairs



Statement from the Chair of the ESPI Advisory Council
Etienne Schneider

Dear friends of ESPI,

In 2024, ESPI Advisory Council welcomed six new personalities - Magali Vaissière, Walther Pelzer, Peggy Hollinger, Lord David Willetts, Maj. Gen. (ret.) Michel Friedling and myself as the new Chair of ESPI Advisory Council. Each of the new members brings a unique expertise and background to the group and together enhance its high-profile nature with a true diversity of perspectives.

Against the backdrop of transformational shifts in Europe and globally, a vision of a strong Europe as a partner to the world, as presented by ESPI in the policy vision for Europe "ESPI2040: Space for Prosperity, Peace, and Future Generations", resonates more than ever. The ESPI Advisory Council endorsed ESPI's continuing work on a consolidated European space strategy 2040 and multiple members actively joined ESPI-led activities throughout 2024.

Building on this example, I am thrilled to note that the ESPI team reinforced active collaboration with Advisory Council members on numerous activities, including the Autumn Conference, ESPI's first Space Policy Summer School and multiple research projects. Acting on the mandate to advise on the mid-term evolution of ESPI, the ESPI Advisory Council met two times in 2024 in the regular group set-up.

The Advisory Council notably addressed the pathways for ESPI's reinforced international role, underlining both the immediate transatlantic repercussions as well as engagement towards a wider landscape beyond traditional partners. The Council explored potential viability of substantiated ESPI presence beyond Europe, in alignment with ESPI mandate to promote space policy globally.

As the competitiveness issue roared through European policy debates, the situation of European space industry was acknowledged as serious concern for European economy and the Council recommended ESPI addresses this issue in its forthcoming work, underlining ESPI's added value in acting beyond national and individual industrial interests.

Last but not least, the Advisory Council underlines the impact ESPI is able to make, not only in the space community but to bring the space stakeholders and the policy makers, including beyond the space bubble, together. It's not only space policy but "Space & Policy" – and who else than an independent space policy institute is better positioned to provide recommendations and proposals, to federate different stakeholders.

Dear readers, ESPI's Advisory Council will continue to advise ESPI in its work and through this contribute to the growth of Europe's space sector and the role of space in European society, economy and security. Now, is the time to join forces— the Advisory Council, the General Assembly, and the ESPI Team—and work towards bringing the ESPI 2040 vision to life.



ESPI Advisory Council



ETIENNE SCHNEIDER
Chair, Former Deputy Prime Minister of Luxembourg



MAREK BANASZKIEWICZ
Former President of the Polish Space Agency



SAMANTHA CRISTOFORETTI
ESA Astronaut, member of the European Astronaut Corps



MAJ. GEN. MICHEL FRIEDLING (RET.)
Former French Space Commander



PEGGY HOLLINGER
International Business Editor at the Financial Times



FRITZ MERKLE
Former Chief Technical Officer at OHB



SINÉAD O'SULLIVAN
Economist at Harvard Business School's Institute for Strategy and Competitiveness



NIKLAS NIENAß
Former Member of the European Parliament



MARGIT MISCHKULNIG
Head of Dept. for Space Affairs at the Austrian Federal Ministry for Climate Action, Environment, Energy, Mobility, Innovation and Technology



WALTHER PELZER
Director General of the German Space Agency at DLR



MAGALI VAISSIÈRE
Member of the Ministerial Space Steering Committee of France 2030



LORD DAVID WILLETTS
Chair of UK Space Agency and President of Resolution Foundation

> The media has woken up the strategic importance of space in this very volatile world. Building strong relations with the press will not just amplify ESPI's very good work, but will help to widen understanding of the complexities, challenges and opportunities in the European and global space sector.
>
> **Peggy Hollinger**
> International Business Editor at the Financial Times and member of the ESPI Advisory Council

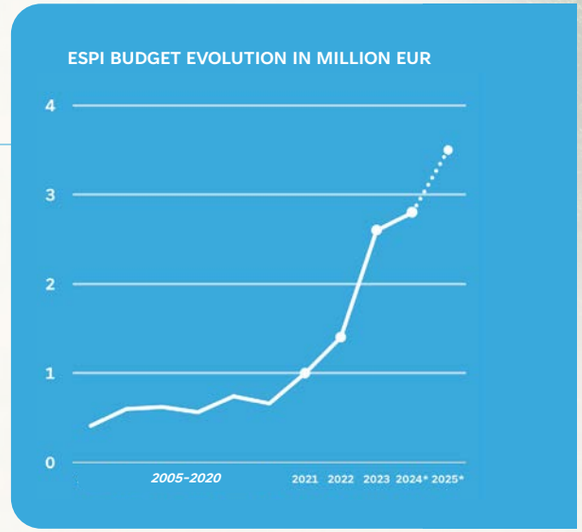


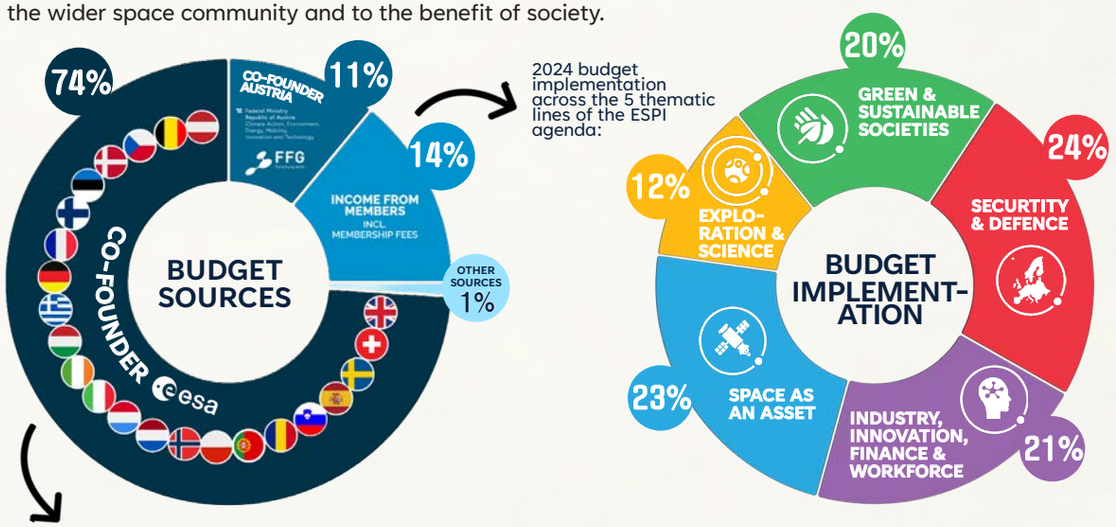
Budget

After a substantial budget increase observed in 2022 and 2023, significantly exceeding the EUR 2 million mark for the first time, ESPI's budget grew further to EUR 2.8 million* in 2024.

This evolution has been enabled primarily due to new agreements with ESA and ASI, and growth of membership and partnerships with European and international partners. During the year, Austria further increased its commitment to ESPI with a new Subsidy Agreement which will take effect from 2025, as part of a budget of EUR 3.5 million approved by ESPI's General Assembly.

These developments, foreseen to contribute to further growth, will allow for the sustainable operation of ESPI and secure its independence at the service of its members and the wider space community and to the benefit of society.





2024 budget implementation across the 5 thematic lines of the ESPI agenda:

ESPI Budget implementation in the three domains of action as identified by the ESPI2024 Vision:



39% **POLICY IMPACT**
Space policy integrated with other policy domains

26% **SPACE CAPABILITIES & AUTONOMY**
Use of space

35% **FOUNDATIONS**
Industrial Base, Science & Technology, Talent & Finance

- 2024 data is indicative (not yet an approved financial statement), 2025 budget approved ESPI General Assembly
- ESA funding approved by all ESA member states
- 6 FTE directly seconded by members not included in budget figures

> Austria supports ESPI because we see the need for having an independent voice for space and of space at European level and also at international level.
>
> **Margit Mischkulnig**
> Head of the Department for Space Affairs at the Austrian Federal Ministry for Climate Action, Environment, Energy, Mobility, Innovation and Technology





BEYOND 2025

BUILDING BRIDGES AND TRUST

EUROPE IN SPACE:

The ESPI2040 Vision, published in 2023, advocated for a vision that "looks beyond the timescale of electoral cycles and governmental policy making, beyond the volatility of the economy and financial markets, beyond the horizon of direct return on investment, and beyond individual decision-making milestones of space programmes".

ESPI2040 could not have anticipated the magnitude of geopolitical shifts we are witnessing today, and the unparalleled urgency of action. Business as usual is no longer a valid option. While a vision and the policy and strategy to implement it needs to have a longer term perspective, it is the next few years, which will decide upon Europe's fate, also in space: To see Europe living up to its economic power, making full use of its unique talent base, leveraging its industrial base to bridge the innovation gap, to develop into a space power, joining forces with other emerging space nations. Or a Europe, which increasingly becomes an observer, dependent as a customer on other space powers.

ESPI2040 advocated for a level of space investment at 0.15% European GDP, a doubling by 2040. In 2024, the group of advisors, experts and ESPI members, elaborated perspectives on European Space Strategies and called for an investment of 0.15%-0.25% GDP. While these numbers, to some, may have appeared largely unrealistic at the time, representing more than a three-fold increase when compared to current investments, these targets today can be considered as a true reference for "whatever it takes", to realize Europe's full ambitions in space. The evolution of national space budgets, of ESA CM25 and CM28 and of the EU MFF budget for space, and their stimulus for private investments will be decisive.

ESPI AGENDA

ESPI will continue to step up its efforts in support of Europe's new level of ambition in space. The Institute is determined to continue its growth, at scale with the overall evolution of Europe in space, and to increase its membership base to reach 25 members from international organisations, governmental entities and agencies, and entities fulfilling the tasks of states. Next to governmental members, guiding the long-term direction of ESPI, an appropriate role of industry with an increasing number of industrial members will be promoted to better leverage public-private dynamics. Beyond a possible increase of presence in Europe, ESPI will explore the viability of a presence beyond Europe such as in the Asia-Pacific region. ESPI increasingly operates on the European level and globally, in a context similar to that of international organisations, and reflections will be made regarding the most adequate institutional evolution, for increasing the resilience of the organization and reflecting its European and international character, within and beyond the framework of a Quasi-International Organisation.

Photo Credit: Adam Jang, Unsplash



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In January 2024, ESPI inaugurated its new premises at Schwarzenbergplatz 16 in the heart of Vienna.